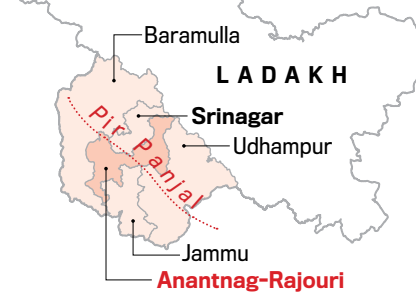




STAR CONTENDERS PDP president Mehbooba Mufti (Left) and DPAP chief Ghulam Nabi Azad (below), are both candidates from the Anantnag-Rajouri seat

Photographs by ANI



JAMMU & KASHMIR

A FIGHT FOR KASHMIR'S FUTURE

Candidates of four Kashmiri parties, including two former J&K CMs, are in a scrum in the new Anantnag-Rajouri constituency. It gives the BJP a chance to get a toehold in the Valley

By **Moazum Mohammad** *in Srinagar*

Winding its way through the Pir Panjal mountains amidst breathtaking scenic beauty, the ancient road into the landlocked Kashmir Valley helped the Mughals under Akbar to gain a foothold in the Valley in the 16th century. Known thereafter as the Mughal Road, the 84-km trans-Pir Panjal road that connects the twin border districts of Rajouri and Poonch in Jammu with Shopian in the Valley can now be seen as an apt symbol of the new political landscape of the Union territory of Jammu and Kashmir in the coming Lok Sabha election. The 2022 delimitation exercise that followed the Jammu and Kashmir Reorganisation Act 2019—which bifurcated the former state into two Union territories—carved out a new parliamentary constituency spread over Jammu's Rajouri and Poonch districts, and Anantnag, Kulgam and some pockets of Shopian districts in the Kashmir Valley. With the giant wall of the Pir Panjal cleaving it into two, the Jammu-Kashmir sections of the new Anantnag-Rajouri LS constituency are separated by ethnicity, climate, language and culture. It is this asymmetric union that allows the BJP the unique opportunity to expand its footprint into the Muslim majority Kashmir Valley.

Though it hasn't announced a candidate, the BJP hopes to do well in this constituency, which comprises 18 assembly constituencies (11 in Kashmir and seven in Poonch-Rajouri). If it wins Anantnag-Rajouri, the BJP can read in it an encouraging sign for future assembly polls—a step towards its goal to form the state government with the help of these seats along with those in Jammu's Hindu-dominated districts. With over 14 lakh voters, Anantnag-Rajouri has 50 per cent Kashmiri-speaking population and nearly 50 per cent Paharis and the Gujjar-Bakerwal pastoral community. The Paharis and Gujjar-Bakerwals are based in Rajouri and Poonch, with some residing in the upper reaches of Anantnag and Kulgam. Previously, the 18 assembly constituencies have been dominated by the National Conference (NC), Congress and the Peoples Democratic Party (PDP).

Anantnag-Rajouri, which goes to the polls on May 7, will decide the electoral fate of two former J&K chief ministers. PDP president Mehbooba Mufti is fighting from here, and so will former Congress leader Ghulam Nabi Azad under the banner of his Democratic Progressive Azad Party (DPAP). Syed Altaf Bukhari's J&K Apni Party has fielded Pahari writer Zafar Iqbal Manhas from the seat. The NC's choice—influential Gujjar-Bakerwal religious leader Mian